



René Magritte, *The Human Condition* (1933)

PSYCHOSOCIAL RESEARCH ROUNDS

Canadian News Media Coverage of AI Chatbots in Mental Health Care: A Framing Analysis of Risks, Benefits, and Agency Distribution

Édouard Coulombe

Faculty of Medicine and Health Sciences, Université de Sherbrooke

Session chaired by Vincent Paquin, MD

October 8, 2026

1:30 PM – 2:00 PM (ET)

ICFP Amphitheatre, 4333 Côte-St-Catherine Rd., Montreal QC H3T 1E4

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Learning objectives

- Explain why news media analysis is relevant to understanding public perceptions and the potential adoption of AI chatbots in mental health care.
- Describe how a media framing approach can be used to examine representations of risks, benefits, and the distribution of agency between AI systems, clinicians, and other stakeholders.
- Reflect on potential risks and benefits of using AI chatbots in mental health care.

Abstract

AI chatbots are increasingly discussed as potential tools in mental health care, raising questions about accessibility, privacy, safety, accountability, and the evolving role of clinicians. Because news media both reflect and shape public discourse around emerging technologies, examining how AI chatbots are portrayed may provide important insight into how their future role in mental health care is being socially constructed.

This presentation will introduce an ongoing study examining Canadian news media coverage of patient-facing AI chatbots in mental health care. The presentation will focus on the rationale for conducting media analyses in this area, the study's framing framework, and its approach to examining representations of risks, benefits, and the distribution of agency between AI systems, clinicians, patients, and other stakeholders. As data extraction is still ongoing, the presentation will primarily emphasize the conceptual and methodological relevance of the project.

About

Édouard Coulombe is a fourth-year medical student at Université de Sherbrooke. His academic and research interests include psychiatry, mental health services, and the ways emerging technologies may influence mental health care and the patient–clinician relationship.

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